HUMAN AND HERITAGE: AN ARCHAEOLOGICAL SPECTRUM OF ASIATIC COUNTRIES

(FELICITATION TO PROFESSOR AJIT KUMAR)

VOLUME - I



EDITORS

RAJESH S. V.
ABHAYAN G. S.
PREETA NAYAR
EHSAN RAHMATH ILAHI

Human and Heritage: An Archaeological Spectrum of Asiatic Countries

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Preeta Nayar
Ehsan Rahmath Ilahi

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208, IInd Floor, Prakash Deep Building
4735/22, Ansari Road, Daryaganj
New Delhi, India – 110002
Ph: 011 – 23280214, 011 – 23280209
E-mail: Deepak.nbbc@yahoo.in

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Editorial

We are happy to bring out *Human and Heritage: An Archaeological Spectrum of Asiatic Countries (Felicitation to Professor Ajit Kumar)* as a symbol of appreciation for the commendable work Prof. Ajit Kumar carried out in the field of archaeological research for the last 36 years. His contributions have covered areas like Buddhist Art, Kerala Archaeology, Ethnography, Rock art, Indian art and Iconography. The role he played in imparting archaeological knowledge to the younger generation and inspiring them to take archaeological research as a profession has been remarkable. There were occasions, especially at its inception stage when the Department of Archaeology started admitting students for Post Graduate courses, he shouldered the responsibility of running a University Department single handedly to the satisfaction of students as well as the authorities of the University.

When we started working on this volume, the response we received from scholars in India and abroad was impressive, and indicative of the respect Prof. Ajit Kumar widely enjoyed in the field of Archaeology. We received 71 articles from established archaeologists and budding scholars, especially the youngsters who pursue Archaeology as a profession, for this volume. These articles dealt with a wide variety of aspects in Archaeology like Prehistory, Protohistory, Iron Age, Historic Period, Art History, Museology, Tourism Studies, Architecture, Ethno archaeology, Numismatics and Iconography.

We, as editors, take this opportunity to thank all the contributors of this volume, who spared their valuable findings with us for the enrichment of this felicitation. We are grateful, in particular, to authors from abroad, who made this publication a remarkable one with their scholarly articles.

We hope that this volume will be useful as an important reference work for all those who are interested and conducting research in Archaeology.

Rajesh S. V., Abhayan G. S., Preeta Nayar and Ehsan Rahmath Ilahi

Editors



Dr. Rajesh S. V. (born 1981) is an Assistant Professor in the Department of Archaeology, University of Kerala. He received his doctoral degree from the Maharaja Sayajirao University of Baroda, Gujarat in the topic of 'A Comprehensive Study of the Regional Chalcolithic Cultures of Gujarat'. His fields of research interests include Indus Civilization, field archaeology, artefact analysis, ancient technology, origin and development of urbanism in South Asia, inter regional interaction networks and Megalithc/Iron Age archaeology. He is serving as the co-editor of the journal 'Heritage: Journal of Multidisciplinary Studies in Archaeology'. He has published more than 50 research articles in journals and edited books and co-edited the book '*Kailashnath Hetu*'. He has participated in several excavations and explorations in India and abroad. He is currently directing a multidisciplinary archaeological research project entitled "Archaeological Excavations at Juna Khatiya and Explorations in Gujarat'.



Dr. Abhayan G. S. (born 1983) is an Assistant Professor in the Department of Archaeology, University of Kerala. His doctoral research from Deccan College, Pune was in the specialization of zooarchaeology, specifically ichthyoarchaeology (studies in fish bones) of Harappan contexts in Gujarat. He has played a vital role in the establishment of Zooarchaeology Laboratory at University of Kerala. He has conducted faunal analyses of several excavated sites representing various time periods across the country. He has keen interest in the Megalithic-Iron Age archaeology of Kerala. He is currently directing a multidisciplinary archaeological research project entitled 'Kerala Megalithic Gazetteer Project'. He has participated in various exploration and excavation works across the country. He has been part of the excavations of archaeological sites in Kerala such as Pattanam, Marayur, Vizhinjam, Arikkadi fort, Kuttikol, Nannangadikkunnu and Enadimangalam; and elsewhere in the country such as Adichanallur (Tamil Nadu), Chaturbhuj Nath Nallah (Madhya Pradesh), Juaffardi (Bihar), Karsola, Lohat (Haryana), Navinal, Madi and Juna Khatiya (Gujarat). He is also serving as the co-editor of the journal 'Heritage: Journal of Multidisciplinary Studies in Archaeology'. He has published 23 research papers in journals, 6 articles in edited books and edited a book '*Kailashnath Hetu*'.



Dr. Preeta Nayar (born 1965) graduated in Archaeology from M. S. University of Baroda, Vadodara, India. She received her Ph.D. degree from the same University in the subject of Indian Iconography. Her main area of research interest, besides Iconography, is the beads of Early Historic Period. A recipient of fellowships from Indian Council for Historical Research, New Delhi and the Ministry of Culture, Government of India, she has handled different aspects of Archaeology in the Department of Archaeology and Ancient History, M S University of Baroda, Department of Archaeology, Kerala University and Kerala Council for Historical Research, Thiruvananthapuram for the last 23 years. She functioned as the Antiquity Registrar and Co director for Pattanam Archaeological Excavation conducted by Kerala Council for Historical Research for six years. A member of the Board of Studies in Archaeology, Kerala University, she is associated with many academic bodies in India and abroad. Extensively travelled in India and abroad with Museums and temple icons in focus, she publishes and lectures on Indian Iconography and beads of Early Historic Period. She edits 'The Proceedings of Indian Art History Congress,' and is one of the editors of the archaeological journal 'The Heritage'. Presently, she functions as a Faculty in the Department of Archaeology, Kerala University, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala, India.



Ms. Ehsan Rahmath Ilahi (born 1995) has a bachelor's degree in English: Language and Literature and a master's degree in Archaeology. She is currently pursuing MPhil degree at the Department of Archaeology in University of Kerala. Her areas of interests reside in Ancient Civilizations, Linguistic studies and Academic Writings. She has been part of the excavations of Juna Khatiya, an Early Harappan cemetery in Kachchh District, Gujarat. She has worked on Indus Script and Graffiti from Gujarat during her Master's days and currently she is researching on Shells and Shell Industry of the Indus Age from Gujarat.

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Contributors

Abhayan G. S.
Department of Archaeology, University of Kerala, Kariavattom Campus, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala – 695581, India, Email: abhayangs@gmail.com

Ajit Kumar
Department of Archaeology, University of Kerala, Kariavattom Campus, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala – 695581, India, Email: ajitkumarku@gmail.com

Ajith M.
Department of Archaeology, University of Kerala, Kariavattom Campus, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala – 695581, India, Email: ajithmadhusoodhan@gmail.com

Akhil K. N.
Department of Archaeology, University of Kerala, Kariavattom Campus, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala – 695581, India, Email: akhilkn2639@gmail.com

Akinori Uesugi
Kansai University, 3-3-35 Yamate-cho, Suita, Osaka 564 – 8680, Japan, Email: southasia.ua@gmail.com

Alka Barthwal
B - 804, Unique Tower, Near NRI colony, Jagatpura, Jaipur, Rajasthan – 302 033, India, Email: alka.barthwal@gmail.com

Ambika Patel
Department of Museology, Faculty of Fine Arts, The Maharaja Sayajirao University of Baroda, Vadodara, Gujarat – 390 002, India, Email: ambikamsu@yahoo.com

Ambily C. S.
Excavation Branch II, Archaeological Survey of India, Pt. Deen Dayal Upadhyaya Institute of Archaeology, Plot No. 2, Zero Point, Greater Noida, Uttar Pradesh – 201 308, India, Email: ambilyananova@gmail.com

Amit Sopan Bhagat
1402, J - Wing 11, Casa Fresco, Lodha Amara, Near Airforce Station, Kolshet, Thane (W), Maharashtra – 400607, India, Email: amit_264@yahoo.co.in

Ananthu V. Dev
Department of Archaeology, University of Kerala, Kariavattom Campus, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala – 695581, India, Email: ananthuvdev@gmail.com

Anjana S. Nair
Department of Archaeology, University of Kerala, Kariavattom Campus, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala – 695581, India, Email: anjanaradhika1996@gmail.com

Apoorva G.
The Indian National Trust for Art and Cultural Heritage (INTACH) - Bengaluru Chapter, 3rd block Jayanagar, Bangalore, Karnataka – 560011, India, Email: apurvagundmi@gmail.com

Arati B. Kulkarni
5, Manikarnika Society, Chintamani nagar, Sahakar Nagar No.2., Pune, Maharashtra – 411 009, India, Email: kulkarniarati@gmail.com

Arun Kumar K. S.
Department of Archaeology, University of Kerala, Kariavattom Campus, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala – 695581, India, Email: arunkumarks105@gmail.com

Arya Nair V. S.
Department of History, University of Calicut, Thenhipallam, Malappuram, Kerala – 673 635, India, Email: aryanairveeyes@gmail.com

Arya P. N.
Department of Archaeology, University of Kerala, Kariavattom Campus, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala – 695581, India, Email: aryapn56@gmail.com

Aswani O. K.
Department of Archaeology, University of Kerala, Kariavattom Campus, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala – 695581, India, Email: aswaniok@gmail.com

Aswathy V. Nair
Department of Archaeology, University of Kerala, Kariavattom Campus, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala – 695581, India, Email: aswathyvnair02@gmail.com

B. Janardhana
Department of Ancient Indian History Culture and Archaeology, Faculty of Social Sciences, Indira Gandhi National Tribal University (IGNTU), Lalpur, Amarkantak, Madhya Pradesh – 484 886, India, Email: janard_97@yahoo.co.in

Bhanu Prakash Sharma
H. No. 9. Savita Bhavan, Darpan Apartments, Near Rail Nagar, Priya Lakshmi Mill Road, Vadodara, Gujarat - 390 003, India, Email: bhanu1927@gmail.com

Bulu Imam
The Indian National Trust for Art and Cultural Heritage (INTACH), Sanskriti Centre, Dipugarha, Hazaribagh, Jharkhand – 825301, India, Email: buluimam@gmail.com

Bushra Beegom R. K.
Department of Sociology, University of Kerala, Kariavattom Campus, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala – 695581, India, Email: bushrabeegom@gmail.com

Ehsan Rahmath Ilahi
Department of Archaeology, University of Kerala, Kariavattom Campus, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala – 695581, India, Email: hartsease412@gmail.com

Gargi Chatterjee
Department of Ancient Indian History, Culture and Archaeology, Banaras Hindu University, Ajagara, Varanasi, Uttar Pradesh – 221 005, India, Email: gargichatterjee09@gmail.com

Hadiqa Imtiaz
Taxila Institute of Asian Civilizations, Quaid-i-Azam University, Islamabad, Islamabad Capital Territory – 45320, Pakistan, Email: imhadiqa@gmail.com

Himanshu Shekhar
Department of A.I.H.C. and Archaeology, Deccan College Postgraduate and Research Institute, Pune, Maharashtra– 411 006, India, Email: himanshusj.shekhar9@gmail.com

Indrachapa Gunasekara
University of Vocational Technology, 100 Kandawala Road, Ratmalana – 10370, Sri Lanka, Email: indrachapag@hotmail.com

Jalaj Kumar Tiwari
Archaeological Survey of India, Archaeological Museum, Chak Ramdas, Vaishali, Bihar – 844128, India, Email: jalajkumartiwari@gmail.com

Jaseera C. M.
Department of Epigraphy and Archaeology, Tamil University, Tamil University Road, Thanjavoor, Tamil Nadu – 613 010, Email: jassiarc@gmail.com

Jenee Peter
Department of History, Union Christian College, Aluva – Paravoor Road, Aluva, Ernakulam Kerala – 683 102, India, Email: jeneepeter@uccollege.edu.in

Justin Imam
Virasat Trust, Tourist Information Centre, NH 33, Behind Kargil Petrol Pump, Hazaribagh, Jharkhand – 825301, India, Email: justinimam@gmail.com

K. P. Rajesh
Department of History, NSS College Manjeri, College Road, Manjeri, Malappuram, Kerala – 676 122, India, Email: keypeerajesh@gmail.com

K. R. Ramasundaram
16 Devan Colony, Muthalamman Koil Street, West Mambalam, Chennai, Tamil Nadu – 600 033, India, Email: krram72@yahoo.com

K. S. Chandra
Department of Ancient Indian History Culture and Archaeology, Rashtrasant Tukadoji Maharaj Nagpur University, Mahatma Jyotiba Phuley Educational Campus, Amravati Road, Nagpur, Maharashtra - 440 033, India, Email: kschandra6@gmail.com

Krishnanjali A. R.
Department of History, Sacred Heart College, Pandit Karuppan Road, Thevara, Ernakulam Kerala – 682 013, India, Email: krishnanjali1995@gmail.com

Kumbhodaran S.
Department of Archaeology, University of Kerala, Kariavattom Campus, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala – 695581, India, Email: kumbhodaran@gmail.com

Kush Dhebar
505 Technology Apartments, 24 I. P. Extension, Patparganj, Delhi – 110092, India, Email: dhebarkush@gmail.com

Lalita Lahari
Department of Ancient Indian History, Culture and Archaeology, Faculty of Social Sciences, Indira Gandhi National Tribal University (IGNTU), Lalpur, Amarkantak, Madhya Pradesh – 484 886, India, Email: lahari.lalita786@gmail.com

M. S. Dhiraj
Department of History, Pondicherry Central University, Kalapet, Puducherry – 605 014, India, Email: haihaidhiru@gmail.com

M. S. Krishna Murthy
Department of Ancient History and Archaeology, University of Mysore, Nobel Laureate Ave, Manasa Gangothiri, Mysuru, Karnataka – 570 006, India, Email: drmsk1945@gmail.com

Mohammed Muhaseen B. S.
Department of Archaeology, University of Kerala, Kariavattom Campus, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala – 695581, India, Email: muhasin.muhammed9@gmail.com

Mohana R.
Department of A.I.H.C. and Archaeology, Deccan College Postgraduate and Research Institute, Pune, Maharashtra– 411 006, India, Email: mohangulya@gmail.com

Muhammed Fasalu K.
Department of Archaeology, University of Kerala, Kariavattom Campus, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala – 695581, India, Email: muhammedfasalu333@gmail.com

N. Sudarsana Kumar
Department of History, Pondicherry Central University, Kalapet, Puducherry – 605 014, India, Email: sudarsannr@gmail.com

Parth R. Chauhan
Department of Humanities and Social Sciences, Indian Institute of Science Education and Research, Mohali, Punjab – 140 306, India, Email: parthrc@iisermohali.ac.in

Preeta Nayar
Department of Archaeology, University of Kerala, Kariavattom Campus, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala – 695581, India, Email: preeta_nayar@yahoo.co.in

Qasid Hussain Mallah
Department of Archaeology, Shah Abdul Latif University Khairpur, Old National Highway, Khairpur Mir's, Sindh – 66020, Pakistan, Email: mallah64@hotmail.com

R. H. Kulkarni
Department of Art History, College of Fine Arts, Karnataka Chitrakala Parishath, Kumara Krupa Road, Bangalore, Karnataka – 560 001, India, Email: kulkarnichalukya@gmail.com

R. N. Kumaran
Archaeological Survey of India, Bangalore Circle, Kendriya Sadan, 5th Floor, F – Wing, Koramangala, Bengaluru, Karnataka – 560 034, India, Email: rnkumaran@gmail.com

Rahul Deshpande
56, Patwardhan Baug, Kondana, Erandavne, Pune, Maharashtra – 411 004, India, Email: deshpanderaahul@gmail.com

Raj K. Varman
Kerala Holiday Mart, Chiramel Building, Sreekandath Road, Ravipuram, Cochin, Ernakulam, Kerala – 682 016, India, Email: rajkkvarman@gmail.com

Rajesh S. V.
Department of Archaeology, University of Kerala, Kariavattom Campus, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala – 695581, India, Email: rajeshkeraliyan@yahoo.co.in

Reni P. Joseph
Department of Archaeology, University of Kerala, Kariavattom Campus, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala – 695581, India, Email: ben14jo@gmail.com

Renjeshlal S. R.
Department of Archaeology, University of Kerala, Kariavattom Campus, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala – 695581, India, Email: renjeshlalsr@gmail.com

Renjinimol M. N.
Department of Archaeology, University of Kerala, Kariavattom Campus, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala – 695581, India, Email: renjinirenju50@gmail.com

Rohinikrishnan R.
Department of History, Pondicherry Central University, Kalapet, Puducherry – 605 014, India, Email: rohinir87@gmail.com

Samseer R. H.
Department of Sociology, University of Kerala, Kariavattom Campus, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala – 695581, India, Email: rhsamseer@gmail.com

Sandra M. S.
Department of Archaeology, University of Kerala, Kariavattom Campus, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala – 695581, India, Email: sandrams815@gmail.com

Saravanan R.
Department of History, University of Hyderabad, Prof. C. R. Rao Road, Hyderabad, Telangana– 500 046, India, Email: shavun@gmail.com

Shad Matthias Gobinsingh
Department of Archaeology, University of Kerala, Kariavattom Campus, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala – 695581, India, Email: shadgobinsingh@gmail.com

Shaik Saleem
Department of Humanities and Social Sciences, Indian Institute of Science Education and Research, Mohali, Punjab – 140 306, India, Email: saleemshaikhdc@yahoo.co.in

Shaikh Musak Rajjak
Department of History, Maulana Azad College, Dr. Rafiq Zakaria Campus I, Rozabagh, Aurangabad, Maharashtra – 431 001, India, Email: shaikhmusakrajjak@gmail.com

Sheena V. R.
Department of Archaeology, University of Kerala, Kariavattom Campus, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala – 695581, India, Email: vr.sheena@gmail.com

Sindhu M. J.
Ushodaya Residency, Rock Town Residents Colony, Sai Nagar, Chanakyapuri, Hyderabad Telangana – 500 068, India, Email: meetindus@gmail.com

Somayye Keighobadi Lemjiri
Department of Archaeology, University of Kerala, Kariavattom Campus, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala – 695581, India, Email: somayye.key@gmail.com

Soorya P.
Department of Archaeology, University of Kerala, Kariavattom Campus, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala – 695581, India, Email: sooryakesavan1992@gmail.com

Sreelatha Damodaran
Department of History, University of Calicut, Thenhipallam, Malappuram, Kerala – 673 635, India, Email: sreelathamohamed@gmail.com

Srikumar M. Menon
School of Humanities, National Institute of Advanced Studies, Bangalore, Karnataka – 560012, India, Email: srikumar.menon@gmail.com

Subhash Bhandari
Department of Earth and Environmental Science, Krantiguru Shyamji Krishna Verma Kachchh University, Near Changleshwar Mahadev Temple, Mundra Road, Bhuj, Gujarat - 370 001, India, Email: subhashbhandari@gmail.com

Syed Shakir Ali Shah
Directorate of Conservation Office, Mohenjo Daro Museum, Dokri, Larkana, Sindh - 77060, Pakistan, Email: Email: shakir_ali_shah@yahoo.co.uk

Umesh Kumar Singh
History of Art Department, Patna University, College of Arts and Crafts, Vidyapati Marg, Behind Patna Museum, Patna, Bihar – 800 001, India, Email: umesharchaeology@gmail.com

V. Ramabrahmam
Department of History and Archaeology, Yogi Vemana University, Vemana Puram, Ganganapalle, Kadapa, Andhra Pradesh - 516 005, India, Email: ram.vellore@gmail.com

Veena Mushrif-Tripathy
Department of A.I.H.C. and Archaeology, Deccan College Postgraduate and Research Institute, Pune, Maharashtra– 411 006, India, Email: veena.mushrif@dcpune.ac.in

Vinay Kumar
Centre of Advanced Study, Department of Ancient Indian History, Culture and Archaeology, Banaras Hindu University, Ajagara, Varanasi, Uttar Pradesh – 221 005, India, Email: vinaykumar166@yahoo.com

Vinay Kumar Gupta
Archaeological Survey of India, Dharohar Bhawan, 24 Tilak Marg, New Delhi, Delhi – 110 001, India, Email: archaeologist1@gmail.com

Vinod V.
Department of History and Archaeology, Marthoma College for Women, Perumbavoor, Ernakulam, Kerala – 683 542, India, Email: vinodarchaeo2003@gmail.com

Vinuraj B.
Archaeological Survey of India, Thrissur Circle, Puratattva Bhavan, FF /19A - K. S. H. B Flats, Pullazhi, Thrissur, Kerala – 680 012, India, Email: vinuraj777@gmail.com

Vishnu Surendran
Department of Archaeology, University of Kerala, Kariavattom Campus, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala – 695581, India, Email: spvishnu95@gmail.com

Vrinda Agrawal
326, The Foothills Colony, SAS Nagar, Mullanpur, Punjab – 140 901, India, Email: vrindagrawal@gmail.com

Vysakh A. S.
Post Graduate Department of History and Research Centre, Sree Narayana College, Chempazhanthy, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala – 695 587, India, Email: padmasreevysh@gmail.com

Wilasinee Chamsaard
Phimai Historical Park, Ananthachinda Rd, Tambon Nai Mueang, Amphoe Phimai, Chang Wat Nakhon Ratchasima - 30110, Thailand, Email: wchamsaard@gmail.com

Worrel Kumar Bain
Anthropological Survey of India, Ministry of Culture, Government of India, Eastern Regional Centre, Kolkata, West Bengal – 700 091, India, Email: worrel.bain@gmail.com

Yadava Raghu
Department of History and Archaeology, Yogi Vemana University, Vemana Puram, Ganganapalle, Kadapa, Andhra Pradesh - 516 005, India, Email: raghuyadav. ethnoarchaeology@gmail.com

Zaheer Uddin Shar
Department of Archaeology, Shah Abdul Latif University Khairpur, Old National Highway, Khairpur Mir's, Sindh – 66020, Pakistan, Email: zaheershar44@gmail.com

A Comparative Study of Material Culture Found from Excavations at Bhokardan and Paunar in Maharashtra

K. S. Chandra

Introduction

Archaeological excavations bring forth the material and cultural history of a site. Most of the time material and cultural history is very much similar at sites, which are geographically located far from each other. During ancient times, these locations were having some sort of cultural, social or economic connections either via land or sea route. One such dynasty, the Satavahanas (Andhras), known for its glory ruled over major part of Deccan from first Century BCE to third Century CE (Figure 1) extending up to Karnataka, Madhya Pradesh, Saurashtra in Gujarat (Figure 2) It was during this time, they established flourishing trade routes through northeast, west and south corridors enabling land and sea trade with local people and foreigners respectively. This also helped in socio cultural and religious growth along with extension of kinship and alliances. One such kinship and alliance is, evidenced from the excavations conducted at Bhokardan (Bhogavardhana), Khandesh and Paunar, Vidarbha region of Maharashtra 350 Kms apart, at both these locations evidence of rich and glorious time during Satavahana reign with lot of similarities in material culture has been found. Both locations give evidence of flourishing towns by the way of coins, seals, and other material culture, out of which one particular object of interest will be appraised, a shell or marble stopper with different motifs found at both the locations in the following pages.

Observation

The two locations Paunar and Bhokardan where excavations were conducted 5 decades ago revealed a rich sequence of Satavahana culture.

Paunar (20°44′30″ N 78°30′20″ E), lies 68 Kms Southwest of Nagpur on Nagpur–Aurangabad Road. The Department of Ancient History and Culture, University of Nagpur, excavated the ancient site of Paunar, believed to be the capital of the Vakatakas. The excavation was, directed by Prof S. B. Deo and assisted by Dr M. K. Dhavalikar in the season 1966-67 (*IAR* 1966-67: 27). The excavation revealed four cultural periods Period I, Period IIA, Period IIB, Period III of which Period III is important in this discussion.

Period III: Witnessed the prosperity of Paunar, this period could be, roughly assigned to late Satavahana and Vakataka times. The ceramic evidence comprised the black-and-red

ware, the Red Polished Ware, the amphora, associated with beautifully made beads of semi-precious stones, late Satavahana coins and a variety of stone plaques and fragmentary stone sculptures. The structures associated with this period, included brick constructions with well-made foundations, ring-wells for soakage purposes and floorings made of rammed clay. The houses had tiled roofs. The tiles bore impressions of rice and wheat husk. A Shell Stopper with couched lion motif (Figure 3) was, found from this level.



Figure 1: Map of Satavahana Empire (Source**:** en.wikipedia.org)

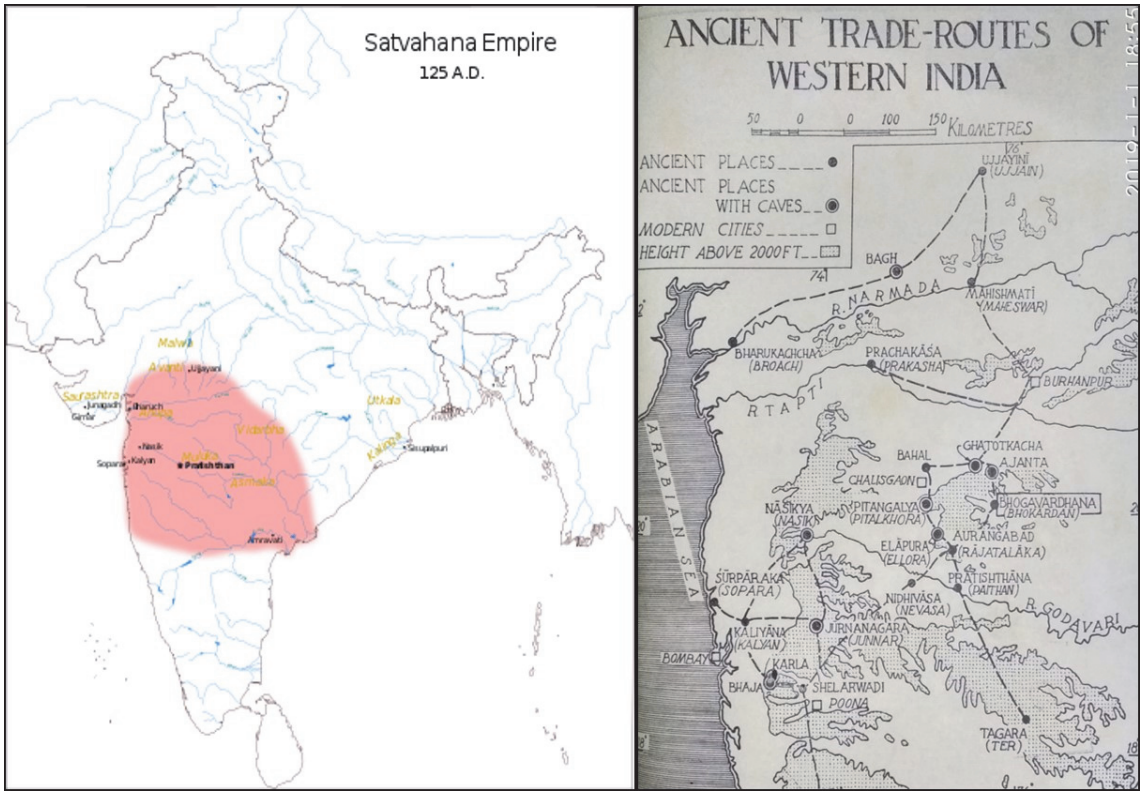


Figure 2: (left) Approximate extent of the Satavahana Empire under Gautamiputra Satkarni, (Nasik *Prashasti*). (John Keay 2008) (Source en.wikipedia.org), (right) Ancient Trade Routes of Western India (Deo and Gupte 1973: Figure 1)

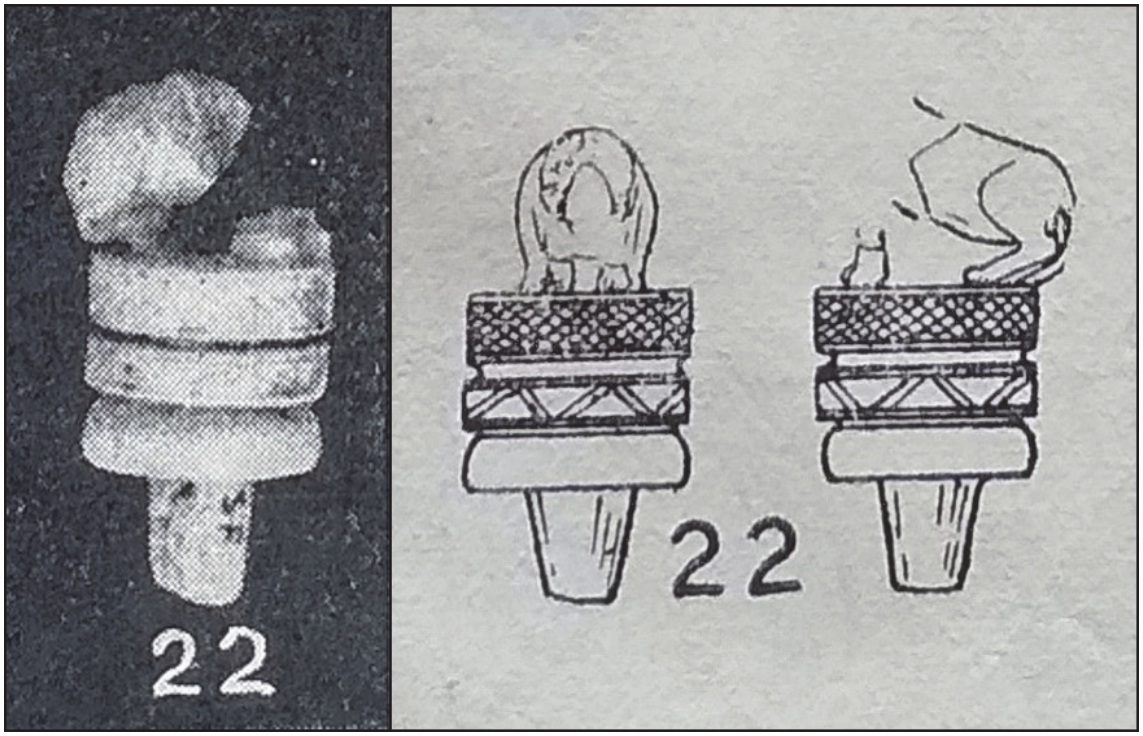


Figure 3: (left) Terminal part of Shell or Marble stopper showing a Lion motif (Paunar 1967: pl XXVII: 22), (right) Drawing of the stopper from Paunar (IAR 1966-67: fig 30:22)

"Fragmentary shell object having a circular pedestal consisting of 3 tiers surmounted by a, jumping lion (?) and a cylindrical tenon at the base of the tiers; the middle one has a crisscross pattern and the uppermost bears incised crisscross pattern; the front part of the lion is missing; from the tenon it appears that the object was used as knob of a lid or probably adorned a mirror handle" (Paunar 1967: 102-3).

Bhokardan (20°15'11" N 75°46'08"E) has been identified with ancient Bhogavardhana, which has been, referred to in the inscriptions at Sanchi and Bharhut and lies 64 km from Aurangabad on way to Ajanta. The *Purāṇas* mention along with Vidarbha a number of *janapadas* among which Bhogavardhana occupies a prominent position. Among its inhabitants, there were persons who won fame as pious donors or as scholars well versed in the *Suttantas.* The territory lies to the west of Bāsim (Vatsagulma), which has been, identified with the Bhokardan tāluk of the Aurangābād district of the Hyderabad state. Within the limits lie the famous Ajanta Caves. In view of this fact, the reference to *Suttanta* scholars dwelling in ancient Bhogavardhana acquires an added significance. If the southern boundary of the ancient *Janapada* stretched southwards as far as the Daulatābād-Jālna Hills it must have included also the village of Ellora, famous for its Buddhist, Jaina, and Brāhmanic caves (Yazadani 1960: 25). The same applies to its Northeastern boundary where towns of Paunar, Mansar (Pravarapura) Nāgardhān (Nandivardhana), Adam, Pauni are situated.

The Universities of Nagpur and Marathwada jointly carried out excavation at Bhokardan, under the direction of Dr S. B. Deo of the Nagpur University, assisted by Dr A. M. Shastri, O. P. Verma, A. P. Jamkhedkar and G. B. Deglurkar and Dr R. S. Gupte and Shri T. V. Pathy of the Marathwada University in the season 1972-73. A large number of surface antiquities, going back to the Satavahana period had already been reported from this site. The site comprises four mounds, rising to an average height of 12 m on both sides of the river Kelna. The present township, situated as it is on the ancient mound, frequently reports the find of Satavahana antiquities. Two mounds were tapped in this season. The mound owned by Shri Dharewal (Md-I) was laid under a grid of trenches, each measuring 5 m. sq. The total area covered was 1000 sq. m. On the mound designated as Mogartakka (Md-III) lying close to the NW of Md-I and separated from the latter by a modern cart track, were laid L-shaped trenches to connect both these mounds.

The total habitation deposit was, distinguished by five structural phases, all belonging to the Satavahana period, as evidenced by over four hundred coins of that dynasty. On the basis of pottery, the deposit could be divided into early and late Satavahana, the latter characterized by the find of amphorae, Red Polished Ware, *bullae* and beads. Both the phases were, however, associated with the black-and-red ware and lead and potin coins of the Satavahanas. Large-scale evidence of brick and clay structures was available. These could be, divided into five phases. The houses had no planned layout and a group of five houses were, found to have been, separated by irregular alleys. The houses had rubble foundations set in black clay, walls, partly built of bricks and partly of clay, roof held in position by wooden posts and covered with typical Satavahana tiles and floors of rammed clay and tile pieces. The pottery comprised bowls and dishes in black-and-red ware; basins, *kujas, handis,* storage jars, stands and storage pots in red-slipped and red-washed wares; a range of utilitarian pots, in blotchy black-and-red ware; and a series of miniature pots in coarse handmade red ware.

In the upper horizon sherds of amphorae, Red Polished and Megarian Wares were recovered. The items of material culture are comprised of:

1. Copper, potin and lead coins

2. Terracotta *bullae* with Greek legends

3. Coin moulds and seals, beads, pendants and amulets of agate, carnelian, crystal, lapis, jade, glass, jasper, faience and terracotta along with bead-moulds.

4. Votive tanks in terracotta of different shapes.

5. Human and animal figurines, ivory and shell bangles, and the shell stopper with bird motif at the top with its neck upraised perched on a round base decorated with crisscross design. Between the end and the round base other decorative moldings, prepared out of columella of a shell, can be seen which was recovered from Period IA (Bhokardan 1973: 196, 120-25) . Other finds include kohl sticks, terracotta ear ornaments, stone rotary querns and saddle querns with Buddhist symbols, burnt grains comprising of wheat, jowar, gram, ber and rice.

Bhokardan seems to have been a centre of various crafts and industries during the Satavahana period (*IAR* 1972-73: 20-21). The artefacts are now on display at Dr. Rai Bahadur Hiralal Memorial Museum, Dept of Ancient Indian History Culture and Archaeology; RTM Nagpur University, Jyotiba Fuley Campus, Nagpur.

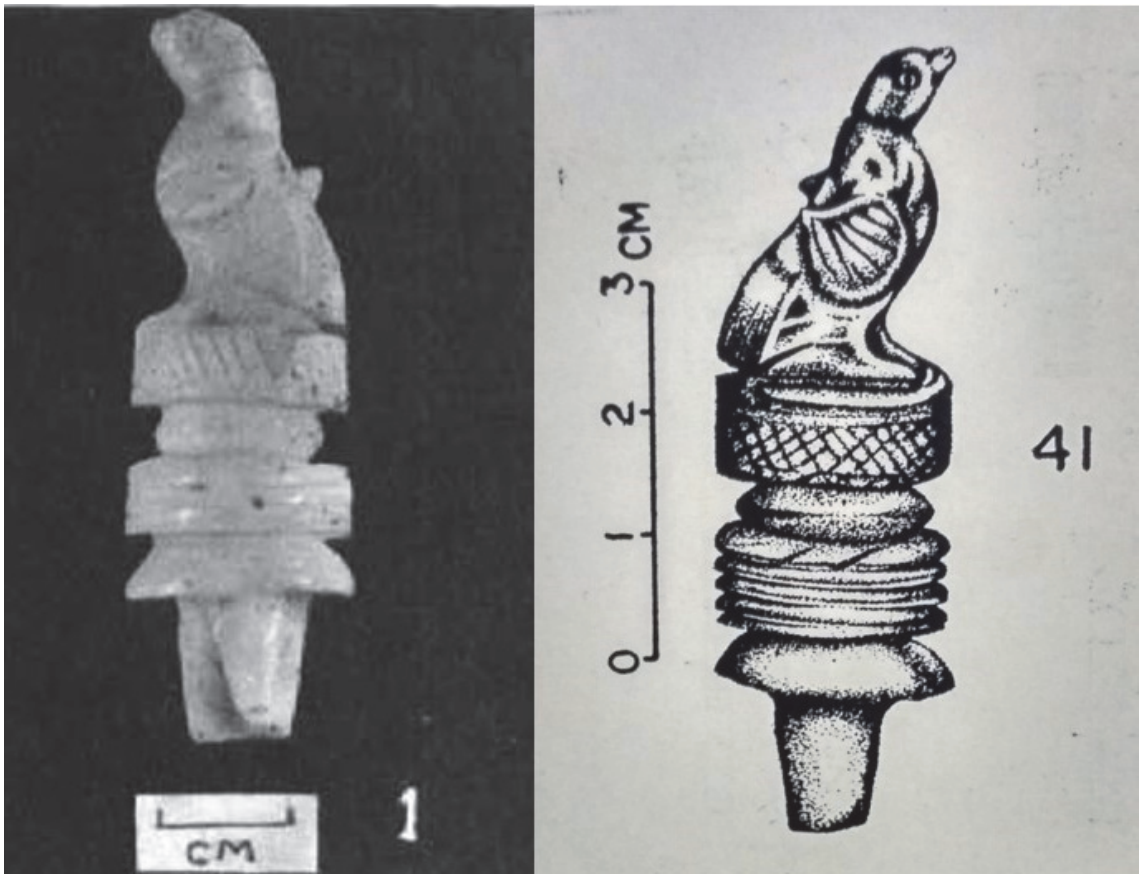


Figure 4: (left) Terminal part of Shell or Marble stopper showing a bird motif (*IAR 1972-73*: pl XXV: B-1), (right) Drawing of the Stopper from Bhokardan (Deo and Gupte 1973: Figure 42:41)

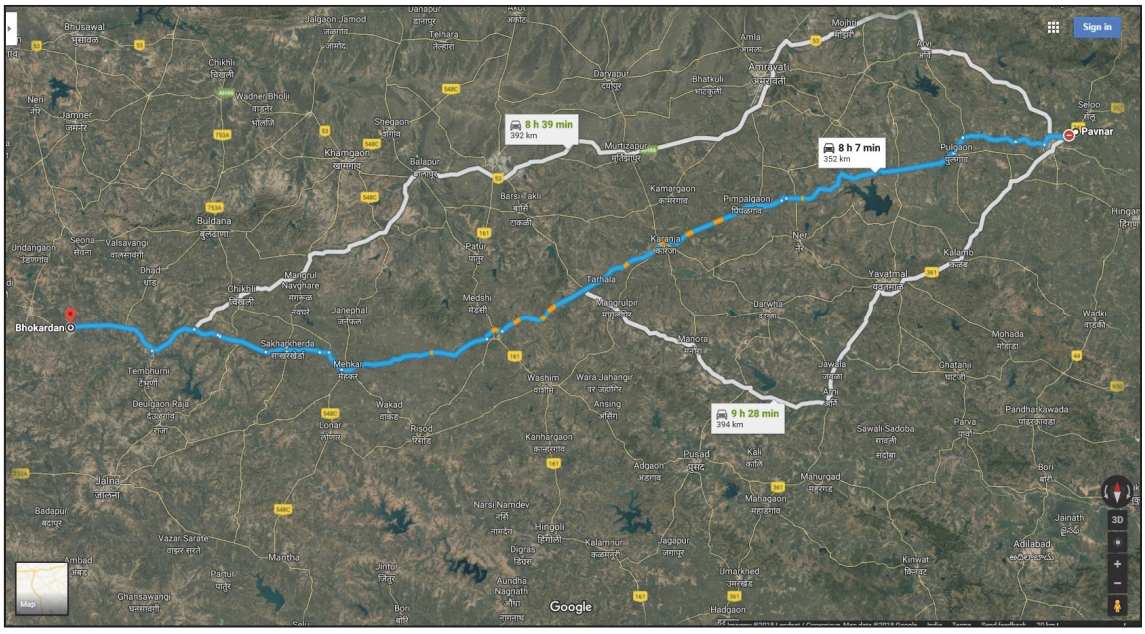


Figure 5: Map Showing Distance between Paunar and Bhokardan and Present-day Travel Time by Road (Source: *Google Maps ©20018 Google*)

Discussion

The artefacts were recovered from Satavahana levels during excavation, from house structures. The other accompanying materials give us an idea that the house must have belonged to an influential person during that times. It also gives us the evidence of socio-cultural relation existing between both the sites during that period. The extant of Satavahana dominion is indicated from the presence of large number of Satavahana coins at both the locations. In ancient times trade routes (Figure 2 right) were well defined. Both these towns happen to fall in the trade route, (Figure 5) and during ancient period the travel time between the two towns must have been around seven days on horseback. Being under Satavahana dominions socio-economic relations were at its peak and Paunar located at the northeast part of dominion must have acted like a buffer between other locations for transit, which is obvious from the rich findings during excavations. The bird and lion motif stoppers might have belonged to incense or perfume bottle or some edible liquid bottle and based on the motifs they might have been, owned by female or male respectively. The artefact with bird motif signifies feminity or to a particular clan or kinship and the same can be, said about the artefact with lion motif, which may be signifying masculinity or belonging to a particular clan or kinship under Satavahana dominion at that particular location revealing the social status of the owner during that time. More over, excavators have mentioned in their report that the knob with lion motif to be part of mirror handle, but the size and shape does not assert to it. They termed the material as shell, but it seems to be made of marble as the texture and fabric is much close to marble than shell, closer analysis will attest about the material. Further finds from excavations or other sources can throw light on this theory.

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